

Decision at a glance

TSA ICR Items 12-15 | EAB decision brief | September 10, 2026

FINDING

Comparable TSA estimation approaches are generally coherent. The clearer observed risk is that published outputs can become disconnected from the analytical inputs that support them.¹

SO WHAT

A reasonable method can still produce a Supporting Statement that is difficult to reproduce, review, renew, or reuse when calculations, tables, labels, footnotes, and prose are maintained separately. This creates an avoidable analytical-control problem.

DECISION REQUESTED

Authorize EAB to pilot a common, source-bound quantitative ICR model on a small number of upcoming renewals or revisions. Generate downstream Items 12-15 tables and draft numerical narrative from one reviewed quantitative source of truth, retaining human analytical judgment and approval.

NEXT MOVE

Select cases covering respondent burden and branching populations, Federal cost by role, and Item 15 baseline/change reconciliation. Test whether a second analyst can reconstruct material outputs and whether supported input changes propagate through calculations, tables, and narrative.

Standardize the controls connecting inputs to outputs while preserving justified analytical differences.

1. *Consistency and defensibility of burden and cost estimation across TSA information collections*. (2026, September 9). [Technical analytical report, 55 pages]. Executive summary; §§10, 14.

What we learned

Strengthen reconciliation while preserving methods that work.

Like activities often use coherent approaches

TSA shows substantial methodological coherence when genuinely comparable work is compared. Many differences have legitimate explanations in task scope, pathway, population, source vintage, payer, or lifecycle.

Six questions still need context

Six task/method questions remain unresolved from public evidence. They require analyst or program context and **are not classified as errors**. A missing public explanation does not establish that no internal rationale exists.

The more actionable weakness is inside individual statements

Inputs, calculations, tables, periods, labels, footnotes, and narrative can diverge even when the underlying method is reasonable. The evidence supports stronger source-bound modeling and deterministic reconciliation more directly than common numeric assumptions across unlike activities. (Technical report, 2026, §§4–7, 10, 14.)

Evidence base	Meaning for this decision
90 recent TSA packages; 48 assigned control histories	Includes historical versions, proposals, and pending submissions
341 quantitative checks across 40 versions	Selected, heterogeneous checks; not complete model validation

These counts do not establish a portfolio error rate. Task/method comparisons and within-ICR findings answer distinct questions; their counts must not be combined. The completed 55-page report remains the authoritative analytical record. (Technical report, 2026, §§1–3, 13.)

Leadership can act on a demonstrated control need without claiming that TSA methods are broadly inconsistent.

Why this matters

A published total is useful only if the next reviewer can understand and reproduce it.

When several representations of an estimate must be maintained separately, a supported change can reach one place and miss another. Leadership then faces a review and continuity problem. The management implications below follow from the completed analysis. (Technical report, 2026, §§8, 10–11.)

Leadership need	What a connected analytical record enables
Review and reproducibility	Trace a material output to its inputs and formula; resolve discrepancies before approval
Renewals and assumption reuse	Identify the prior model, determine which assumptions still apply, and update supported inputs
Change accounting	Connect the applicable baseline, component changes, and new total
Economic and regulatory reuse	Retain task scope, population, period, and valuation context before adapting an estimate
Institutional memory	Preserve sources and analytical decisions so another analyst can reconstruct the work

A practical scope for EAB

EAB can require a common way to record sources, assumptions, calculations, and reconciliation results without standardizing every numerical assumption. Different tasks can retain different times, wages, or proxies when their applicability is documented.

The proposed benefits are prospective and unmeasured. This analysis does not assess individual analysts or infer undocumented internal causes.

Make the analytical record easier to review, carry forward, and use responsibly.

Where the controllable risk appears

Pipeline cybersecurity: a coherent role-based method, an output that does not reproduce.²

The Federal plan-review example displays **100 reviews**, with the following inputs for each plan:

Role	Hours per plan	Hourly rate
Manager	8	\$122.27
Analyst	24	\$104.17

Displayed inputs reproduce approximately \$347,824

$100 \times [(8 \times \$122.27) + (24 \times \$104.17)] = \textbf{\$347,824}$

Published amount: \$290,825.84

The role-based method itself is coherent, but the displayed inputs do not reproduce the published output. (TSA, Pipeline Supporting Statement A, 2026, Item 14.)

\$347,824 is not an official corrected estimate or an estimate of actual spending. Public evidence does not establish which alternative underlying inputs or recurrence convention should govern. (Technical report, 2026, §7.9.)

This is exactly the class of problem a deterministic model-to-output reconciliation control should detect before publication.

Analysts would still determine the appropriate assumptions and resolve the discrepancy. The control would make the mismatch visible before approval.

2. Transportation Security Administration. (2026, January 2). *Pipeline Corporate Security Reviews and TSA Security Directive Pipeline–2021–02 Series: Supporting Statement A* (OMB Control No. 1652-0056; ICR 202512-1652-001). U.S. Department of Homeland Security. [Registered Supporting Statement](#). Item 14.

What good looks like

The validated TWIC Item 15 bridge demonstrates traceable change accounting.³

For the Transportation Worker Identification Credential (TWIC) collection, the current statement identifies the new burden and component changes. The predecessor statement independently supports the prior baseline.⁴

Reconciliation step	Annualized burden hours
Prior baseline	430,317
+ Net of six displayed component changes	+80,154
= New burden	510,471
Residual	0

Prior baseline + component changes = new burden. A reviewer can follow the arithmetic from the identified starting point to the new total. (TSA, TWIC Supporting Statement A, 2025b, Item 15; Technical report, 2026, §7.10.)

This is a verified arithmetic/component bridge, **not a complete causal decomposition** of population, task time, pathway shares, or interactions. It does not validate other Item 15 baselines.

TSA also uses coherent recurring structures for documentation tasks, training activities, and review by staff role. Their continuity does not independently validate every coefficient for future use. (Technical report, 2026, §4.)

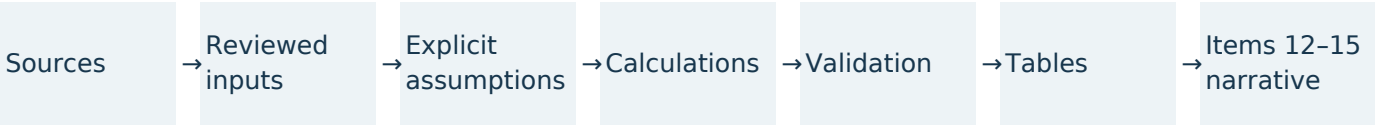
Preserve what works; systematize the controls around it.

3. Transportation Security Administration. (2025b). *Transportation Worker Identification Credential: Supporting Statement A* (OMB Control No. 1652-0047; ICR 202504-1652-008). U.S. Department of Homeland Security. [Registered Supporting Statement](#). Item 15.

4. Transportation Security Administration. (2025a). *Transportation Worker Identification Credential: Supporting Statement A* (OMB Control No. 1652-0047; ICR 202502-1652-004). U.S. Department of Homeland Security. [Registered Supporting Statement](#). Item 12; annualized baseline.

What would change

One reviewed quantitative source of truth; multiple derived outputs.



This is the proposed workflow. Each downstream numerical statement derives from the same reviewed calculation, with its sources and applicable period retained. (Technical report, 2026, §§10–11.)

One approved change, consistently reflected

If an approved wage changes, update that input once. The model recalculates the role cost, updates every dependent table, and refreshes the draft numerical statement. The same principle applies to an approved population or frequency change.

Human analysts decide	Deterministic software handles
Task scope and assumption applicability	Reproduction of declared formulas
Proxy selection and economic interpretation	Arithmetic and baseline reconciliation
Unresolved inputs and issue disposition	Checks of declared units, periods, and population relationships
Final narrative and publication approval	Generation of dependent tables and draft numerical language

Review remains essential

A calculation can reproduce exactly and still rely on an unsuitable assumption. Analysts establish the relationships, resolve missing evidence, and approve interpretation. Software checks whether the declared relationships reproduce and remain synchronized.

Automate reproduction and reconciliation while retaining analytical judgment and approval.

Pilot the approach

Use a small number of upcoming renewals or revisions to test reconstruction and controlled change.

Select cases that exercise the key relationships

Choose respondent burden with branching populations, Federal cost by role, and an Item 15 baseline/change bridge. One collection may cover more than one need. Confirm access to underlying models and source inputs before fixing the scope. (Technical report, 2026, §12.)

Produce a complete, reviewable pilot record

- Source/provenance registry and explicit assumptions with applicability recorded.
- Formula-preserving quantitative model and deterministic QA with visible issue dispositions.
- Item 15 baseline/change ledger where applicable.
- Generated tables and draft numerical Supporting Statement language for Items 12–15.
- Human analytical review and second-analyst reconstruction of material outputs.

Proposed responsibility	Pilot role
EAB	Define the model and checks; document assumptions and results
Program partners	Clarify task scope, inputs, and assumption applicability
PRA reviewers	Review Supporting Statement requirements and draft outputs
Second analyst	Independently reconstruct material outputs and test supported changes
Leadership	Confirm assignments and assess whether to revise, expand, or stop

Establish acceptance measures before building

Can a second analyst trace and reproduce material outputs? Does a supported input change reach every dependent table and numerical statement? Do checks flag deliberate mismatches while accepting justified differences and valid bridges?

The pilot tests feasibility and control quality. It claims no measured savings, staffing reductions, implementation ROI, or elimination of analytical judgment.

Decision and next move

Decision requested

Authorize the bounded EAB pilot of a common, source-bound quantitative ICR model.

Use the pilot to establish whether a reviewed model can reliably generate tables and draft Items 12–15 numerical language while supporting independent reconstruction. (Technical report, 2026, §12.5.)

Immediate actions

The following is a **proposed sequencing framework**, subject to case availability and confirmed responsibilities; these are not established program commitments.

Proposed timing	Action and review point
0–30 days	Select pilot ICR(s); confirm EAB, program, and PRA roles; identify available underlying models and source inputs; establish acceptance measures
30–60 days	Construct the common quantitative model; run source/provenance and reconciliation controls; generate draft outputs; conduct second-analyst reconstruction
60–90 days	Assess reconstruction quality, unresolved issues, and maintenance burden; determine whether to revise, expand, or stop

Return to leadership with evidence

Report what reconstructed successfully, what failed to propagate, which assumptions remain unresolved, and what maintaining the model required. Use those results to decide the next step; operational benefits remain to be measured.

Authorize the pilot, confirm accountable roles, and require a results-based decision on expansion.

References

Only sources cited in this brief are listed. Public document links use the exact registered locators.

Consistency and defensibility of burden and cost estimation across TSA information collections. (2026, September 9). [Technical analytical report, 55 pages].

Transportation Security Administration. (2026, January 2). *Pipeline Corporate Security Reviews and TSA Security Directive Pipeline-2021-02 Series: Supporting Statement A* (OMB Control No. 1652-0056; ICR 202512-1652-001). U.S. Department of Homeland Security. [Registered Supporting Statement](#).

Transportation Security Administration. (2025a). *Transportation Worker Identification Credential: Supporting Statement A* (OMB Control No. 1652-0047; ICR 202502-1652-004). U.S. Department of Homeland Security. [Registered Supporting Statement](#).

Transportation Security Administration. (2025b). *Transportation Worker Identification Credential: Supporting Statement A* (OMB Control No. 1652-0047; ICR 202504-1652-008). U.S. Department of Homeland Security. [Registered Supporting Statement](#).